LESSON 0 · SEEING THE SYSTEM

Meridian Health

A fictional digital-health company, and the production system its new platform team inherits

Building an Internal Developer Platform · after *Thinking in Platforms* by Kaspar von Grünberg and Luca Galante

Meridian at a glance

600	110	14	6
employees	engineers	product teams	products

Founded 2018 · offices in Lisbon and Boston · fully on AWS under a signed Business Associate Agreement

Regulated: **HIPAA** applies, **SOC 2 Type II** held, **HITRUST** certification in progress

Six products, one regulated data estate

Patient app

Booking, health records and messaging for patients on mobile

Clinician portal

Web workspace where care teams review patients and document visits

Telehealth

Video visits between patients and clinicians

Prescription refills

Refill requests routed to partner pharmacies

Claims and billing

Insurance claims, invoicing and payments

EHR Integration Hub

FHIR and HL7 data exchange with partner hospitals

How software reaches production today

Area	What happens	What it costs
Compute	Half the services on EKS (migration stalled), the rest on ECS, three legacy EC2 services	Two platforms to run; nobody owns finishing
CI	Every team writes its own GitHub Actions; billing still runs Jenkins	14 ways to build the same thing
Infrastructure	A Jira ticket to the three-person Cloud Ops team	Median 9 business days per resource
Production deploys	Helm charts and shell scripts written by one senior SRE, Tomás	Releases pause when he is away
Security review	Data Protection Review: a form, then a weekly review board	Median 12 business days

Three signals the system is already sending

5 weeks

for a new engineer to ship a first production change

→ organizational learning

1 finding

SOC 2 auditors asked who changed a production S3 bucket policy, and why. Nobody could show it.

→ state, later

“Not PHI”

Teams describe new resources as holding no patient data to skip the 12-day review

→ policy and incentives

The people around the platform

Helena

CTO

Back from a conference wanting a developer portal “like Spotify’s.” Mandate: Backstage live by end of Q2, four headcount, KPIs on deployment frequency.

Raj

CISO

Believes healthcare is too regulated to standardize: every service is special, so every review stays manual.

Engineering managers

14 TEAMS

Measured on roadmap delivery. Mostly want to be left alone to hit their dates.

You

LEAD PLATFORM ENGINEER

Newly hired. No team yet, no paths yet, and a mandate you didn’t write.

THE LEAD'S DIAGNOSIS

Before choosing a single tool, diagnose the system you walked into.

The book's starting point: performance improves when the system around the work is treated as a product, not when people are pushed harder.

Four production systems, two axes

↑ MORE EXPLICIT WORKFLOW DESIGN

Bureaucratic

Explicit and controlled, ownership fragmented. Stable, slow.

Data Protection Review board

Platform-based

Designed explicitly and owned continuously, as a product.

Nothing here yet: the target

Artisanal

Informal coordination, implicit interfaces. Varies.

14 CI setups · stalled EKS migration

Hero-based

Knowledge concentrated in a few people. Owned, but fragile.

Deploys via Tomás · Cloud Ops queue

MORE CONTINUOUS END-TO-END OWNERSHIP →

The book sorts production systems by how explicitly work is designed and how continuously someone owns it end to end.

Meridian isn't one archetype. It's the "uneasy mix" the book describes: each step of its delivery path sits in a different quadrant.

Diagnosis: a hero-based core with bureaucratic gates

WHAT DOMINATES

The critical path to production runs through people, not through a system.

- Every EKS deploy depends on one SRE's scripts
- Every new resource waits in one small team's queue
- Every PHI decision waits for one weekly board

WHERE IT ENTERS THE COST LOOP

Fragility first, with governance expansion close behind.

The audit finding will tempt leadership to add more manual review. That is the bureaucratic over-correction the book warns about, and it would make the "not PHI" workaround worse.

Six value vectors, scored

Value vector	Score	Evidence
Delivery velocity	2 / 5	Resources wait 9 days, reviews 12; releases pause for one person
Outcome predictability	2 / 5	The same kind of service is built and shipped 14 different ways
Operational resilience	1 / 5	One engineer's absence stops production deploys
Maintenance efficiency	2 / 5	Two compute platforms and a Jenkins island, all maintained in parallel
Organizational learning	2 / 5	Five weeks to a first change; no record of who changed what, or why
Incentive alignment	1 / 5	Labelling data "not PHI" is the rational way to ship on time

Misconceptions in the room, and the reframes

Who	The belief	The reframe, in plain language
Helena, CTO	“Our tools are our platform” Misconception 5	A portal is one doorway. First decide what developers should be able to do; tools and portals come after.
Raj, CISO	“We’re too complex to standardize” Misconception 4	Most services combine a handful of building blocks. Encode your rules once per block, and your team stops re-reviewing the same thing.
Engineering managers	“Optimizing each team optimizes the org” Misconception 2	Each setup makes sense locally, but 14 setups can’t share a single fix. And we do the migration work, so no roadmap pays for it.

Responding to the CTO’s mandate

Accept

- The goal: faster, safer delivery for developers
- Her sponsorship, stated publicly

Decline, for now

- Backstage by Q2 as the deliverable
- Four headcount up front
- Deployment frequency as the success KPI: a lagging indicator

Ask instead

- A few weeks to interview developers
- Then a 3×3 proposal: 3 people, 3 paths, 3 months
- Measured by the cost of today’s friction

The book’s US insurance case started exactly like this mandate. Its lesson: push back politely, then go to users first.

Next: Stage 1, Getting Started

01

Discovery interviews

Five or more with the most average developers

02

Friction and intents

Value stream, friction points, recurring intents

03

Cost of inactivity

Runs × hours × loaded cost, as a lower bound

04

Rank three teams

Representative, open, important but not existential

05

The 3×3 pitch

Back to Helena with evidence, not a vision

No code until discovery has chosen a path.